

MANUEL ECHAVARRÍA ROMERO

Senior Product & Brand Innovation Designer

Consumer products · Retail & point of sale · AI · Brand experience · Physical & digital

Portfolio **www.manecharo.com**

Understand before solving. Design to make life easier.

Industrial designer trained in Milan. **Fifteen years** turning consumer, brand and business problems into things that really exist: manufactured products, point-of-sale systems installed, digital platforms in production. Has co-founded three companies, **one sold, two being built**. Combines research and synthesis with hands-on design, prototyping, manufacturing and launch, connecting strategy and execution beyond the concept.

His work sits at the intersection of what people need, what a brand has to communicate and what a business can actually deliver. Has led design teams, co-founded and sold his stake in a product company, worked in six countries and taken projects from insight and concept through to production, distribution and digital rollout.

IMPACT IN NUMBERS

−70% technology cost · MILL	**65%** cheaper than the imported system · PAQUA	**3** Companies co-founded, from idea to market
+1,000 units sold · PAQUA	**400+** artisans trained · ARTESANÍAS DE COLOMBIA	**1.4 M** views in year one · KUASA

CONSUMER / USER INSIGHT
Research-led design: Futtem (https://www.futtem.com/) was built on research with more than 600 participants; physical products were designed around use, adoption, cost and manufacturing reality.

BRAND + RETAIL EXPERIENCE
Brand identity, retail systems, POP technology and interactive fixtures; Mill's solutions were adopted by major consumer brands, among them SAB Miller.

PRODUCT INNOVATION
From concept to manufactured product: hydroponic gardens (paqua.co/), interactive retail systems, doors, furniture (see Portfolio) and digital products currently in production (bpetit.com; girotours.co/).

COMMERCIAL / BUSINESS SENSE
Design aimed at viability: Paqua came in 65% cheaper than the imported alternatives; Mill cut technology cost by 70% through local manufacturing.

SYSTEMS + SCALABILITY
Builds repeatable systems: Paqua, a device-system for urban gardens, passed 1,000 units across four families; at Artesanías he developed a national product system.

HANDS-ON / MULTIDISCIPLINARY EXECUTION
From strategy to sketch, prototype, supplier, production or code; used to entrepreneurial pace and multidisciplinary work.

EXPERIENCE

2026 — present **OLOSOMA — Co-founder** · remote / Spain

- Strategic design studio: architecture, product, brand and digital in one team and one contract. Fixed scope, defined deliverables.
  olosoma.com

2019 — present **Product and brand designer, independent** · international

- United Nations (UNDP, UNICEF / Education Cannot Wait) under framework agreement · Vertikal, art metaverse (Switzerland) · Cloud9World · Prosectra · Artemisas · **more than ten brand identities**.
- **FOLD** (2020): emergency face mask for **under 1 USD**, released open source so that anyone could make it.
- Since 2024 he designs **and codes** his own products: **Bpetit**, clinical records for pets — **bpetit.com** — and **Giro**, a marketplace for city audio guides — **girotours.co**. Both in production.

2023 — present **KUASA — Brand and content consultant** · Kuala Lumpur

- Rebuilt the brand and the content system, and set up an AI-assisted video pipeline for education in Malay.
- The weekly show passed **1.4 M views in its first year**.

2023 — 2024 **Futtem — Co-founder and founding designer** · remote

- Full UX/UI and identity. With his partner, the business model and the investor pitch.
- Product and experience decisions taken on research with **more than 600 participants**.

2019 **Extituto de Política Abierta — Design and communication director** · Bogotá

- Brand and communication from scratch.
- Led *Wikipaz*, a citizen consensus platform that brought together some **1,500 participants**, and redesigned the debate format *Polas Opuestas* with the Konrad Adenauer Foundation, a debate programme.

2018 **Artesanías de Colombia — Head of design, Antioquia** · Medellín

- Redesigned how **400 artisans** produce, design and tell the story of their work: timings, finishes, repeatability and cost per piece, without touching the traditional craft.
- With his team: a national product line, a register of crafts, training for people who are not designers and **material that tells who is behind each piece**.

2013 — 2017 **PAQUA — Co-founder and design director** · Bogotá

- Hydroponic urban garden platform, from concept to market: product, manufacturing, packaging, distribution and subscription service.
- **65% cheaper than the imported system.** More than **1,000 units** across four product families.
- Nutrients developed by the team, plus a school of urban agriculture. **Three of their gardens became the livelihood — a pesto cooperative — of women heading their own households, victims of the armed conflict.**
- Sold his stake in 2018; the company is still alive — **paqua.co**

2012 — 2016 **MILL, a Visión & Marketing venture — Design director** · Bogotá

- Redesigned for Colombia an interactive point-of-sale technology that only existed as an import, at an unworkable price: **cut its cost by 70%** using Korean technology and local manufacturing.
- A system **that fits the coolers the market already used, instead of replacing them**. Led the R&D team on thermal, electrical and sheet-metal design.
- Adopted by major consumer brands, among them **SAB Miller**.
- POP systems and interactive retail fixtures: for **John Restrepo**, a fixture that replaced the in-store promoter.

EARLIER

2020 **UMECIT, Panama — Lecturer.** Seminars in communication and design.

2014 — 2015 **Atípico, Bogotá — Partner and manager.** A *slow food* concept: full brand and a team of 18.

2011 — 2012 **Porta Drzwi, Poland — Product designer.** Two complete lines at one of the country's largest door manufacturers; introduced new 3D modelling techniques.

2008 — 2011 **Milan and Barcelona.** Furniture, interiors and trade fairs at Studio Koster and Studio 02, alongside the master's; before that, three months with **Pepe Cortés** in Barcelona.

EDUCATION

2009 — 2011 **Scuola Politecnica di Design, Milan** Master in Product Design + Master in Interior Design

2006 — 2009 **Istituto Europeo di Design, Milan** BA in Industrial and Product Design

2019 — 2020 **Harvard — Derek Bok Center** Higher Education Teaching Certificate

2024 **MIT Professional Education** AI and machine learning

2021 **freeCodeCamp** Responsive web design · JavaScript

INTERNATIONAL PROFILE

NATIONALITY Colombian and Spanish.

REACH Six countries, four continents.

LANGUAGES Spanish native · English C1 · Italian B2 · French A2

CAPABILITIES AND TOOLS

Brand and consumer Brand identity and experience · retail and *shopper* · POP systems · consumer research · design systems

Physical product Industrial design · CMF · design for manufacture · prototyping · cost engineering · production and suppliers

Digital UX/UI · Figma · prototyping · HTML / CSS / JavaScript · Webflow · Python · AI-assisted workflows

3D and workshop Rhino 3D · 3ds Max · Blender · Adobe Creative Suite · Arduino and sensors · 3D printing

CONTACT

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